SkillNavora

MODULE 11 HANDBOOK

Module 11: Journey Builder

5 sections, 43 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 11: Journey Builder

Level: Intermediate. Journeys: entry sources, activities, splits, testing and troubleshooting.

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Detailed lessons

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11.1 Entry sources and activities

WHAT IS IT?

> A journey starts with an entry source (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience) and moves contacts through activities: email, SMS, push, wait, decision splits, engagement splits, random splits and update contact.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Journeys deliver the multi-step experiences customers expect, from welcome series to renewal reminders.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose an entry source that updates in near real time for triggered journeys.
2. Add an email activity and a wait activity.
3. Add a decision split on a data field (for example, plan type).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Welcome journey: entry on sign-up, welcome email, wait 2 days, decision split on first login.

COMMON ERRORS

Entering contacts from a data extension that is refreshed once a week and expecting real-time triggers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an entry source and how do you choose one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a three-step welcome journey on paper with entry, email, wait and a split.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Journey Builder documentation (Salesforce)

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11.2 Re-entry, exit criteria and testing

WHAT IS IT?

> Re-entry rules decide whether a contact can enter again. Exit criteria stop contacts who have completed or unsubscribed. Test with a test data extension before activating.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A wrong re-entry rule either floods a contact with messages or stops them from ever re-entering.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Set re-entry rules explicitly.
2. Add an exit on unsubscribe.
3. Test with a small test population, then review contact tracking.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Abandoned cart: re-entry allowed after 7 days, exit when the order completes.

COMMON ERRORS

Leaving re-entry at default without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot a journey that does not accept contacts?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the test plan for an abandoned cart journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

11.1 Journey Builder Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is Journey Builder?. The tool to build multi-step, multi-channel journeys.

Journey architecture. Entry source, activities, splits, waits and exits on a canvas.

Customer journey concepts. A sequence of messages and decisions that follows customer behaviour.

Journey creation. Create the journey, choose the entry source and add activities.

Journey configuration. Settings such as re-entry, goals, exit criteria and contact evaluation.

Journey activation. Validate and activate; changes after activation create new versions.

11.2 Entry Sources: every topic explained

Data Extension Entry Source. Contacts enter from a data extension on a schedule or when rows are added.

API Event. Contacts enter when an external system calls the API with event data.

Salesforce Data Entry. Contacts enter when Salesforce CRM records are created or changed (needs the connector).

Audience Entry. Contacts enter from an audience, for example from Data Cloud where licensed.

Automation-related entry. An automation populates the data extension used by the entry source.

Entry event configuration. Defines the data schema and how entries are evaluated.

Entry filters. Rules that limit who enters.

Re-entry rules. Whether a contact can enter again: no re-entry, any time, or only after exiting.

11.3 Journey Activities: every topic explained

Email activity. Sends an email to the contact.

SMS activity. Sends an SMS (MobileConnect licence).

Push notification activity. Sends an app push notification (MobilePush licence).

Wait activity. Pauses for a duration, until a date, or until an event.

Decision Split. Routes contacts by data rules.

Engagement Split. Routes by email engagement (opened, clicked, bounced).

Random Split. Splits contacts randomly for tests.

Update Contact. Writes a value to a data extension for tracking.

Salesforce activities where supported. Create or update CRM records from the journey (with the connector).

Custom activities. Partner or custom activities that call external services.

Exit criteria. Rules that remove contacts once a goal or condition is met.

11.4 Advanced Journey Design: every topic explained

Multi-step journeys. Journeys with several messages over days or weeks.

Multi-channel journeys. Journeys that mix email, SMS and push.

Branching logic. Splits that send contacts down different paths.

Customer lifecycle journeys. Onboarding, active, lapsing and win-back stages.

Abandoned cart journeys. Reminders after a cart is abandoned, stopped once the order completes.

Welcome journeys. A series that introduces new customers to the brand.

Renewal journeys. Reminders before a subscription or policy renewal.

Re-engagement journeys. Messages for inactive contacts, with a sunset rule.

Transactional journeys. Receipts and notices as part of a journey.

11.5 Journey Testing and Monitoring: every topic explained

Journey validation. The built-in check that the journey is configured correctly.

Testing. Testing with test contacts and test mode where available.

Entry event testing. Fire test events and check that contacts enter.

Journey versioning. Each change after activation is a new version; manage old versions.

Journey activation. Make it live and monitor the first entries.

Contact tracking. See where a contact is in the journey.

Error handling. Handle failed activities and contacts in error.

Journey performance. Entries, exits, goals and message results.

Troubleshooting. Check entry source, filters, re-entry, data and journey status.